

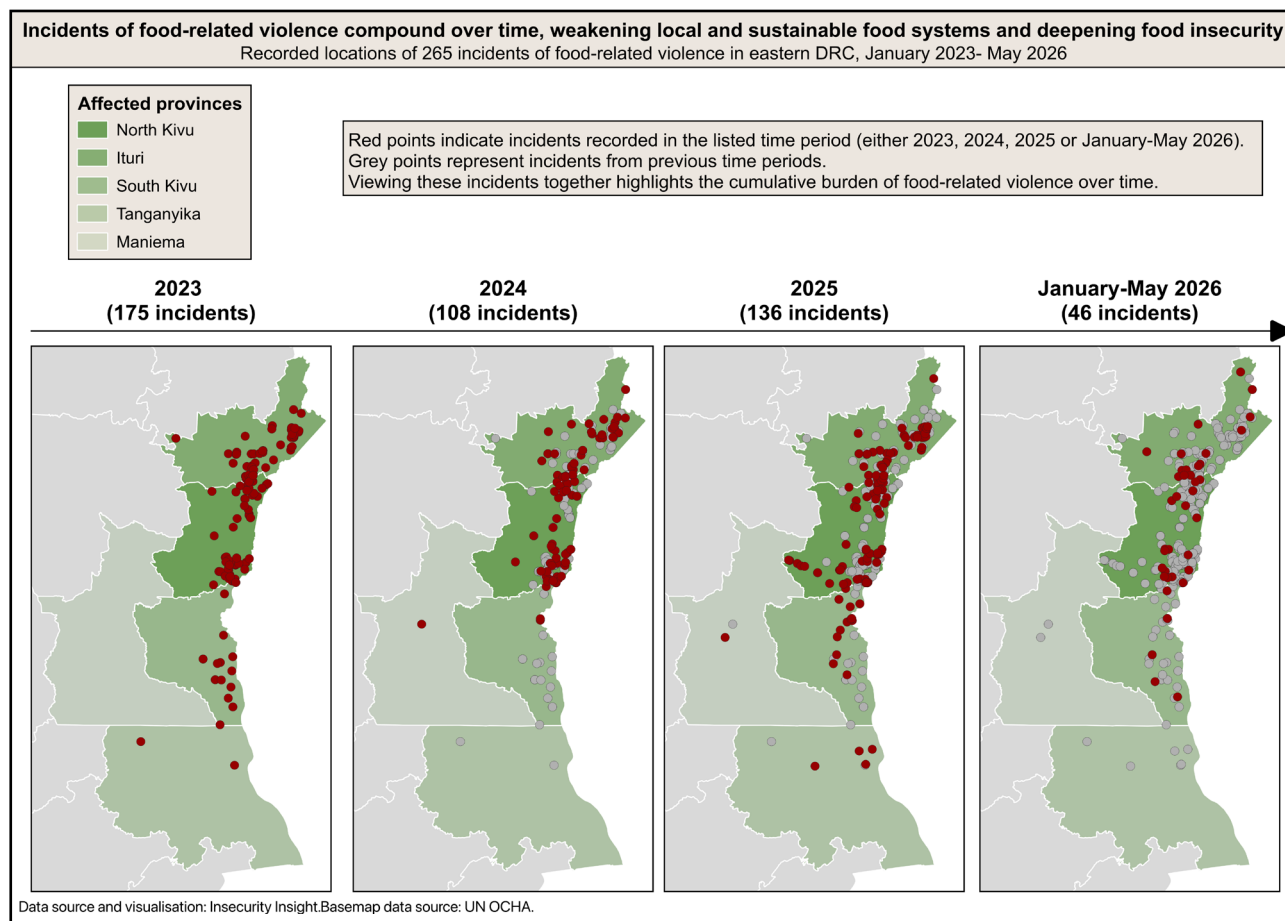
Anticipatory Action and Risk Mitigation of Food- Insecurity in Eastern DRC

January 2023 to May 2026



Key findings

- Insecurity Insight data, obtained through continuous open-source monitoring of incidents of conflict-related violence, providing an overview of reported damage and destruction to local food systems, indicating areas with growing strain on food production and distribution.
- Food-related violence was geographically concentrated, with the vast majority occurring in North Kivu (55%) and Ituri (37%), which together accounted for 92% of all recorded incidents.
- Local and sustainable food systems, as well as humanitarian aid, have repeatedly been subjected to a variety of conflict violence, the impacts of which compound over time and continue to undermine food security in eastern DRC today.
- 61% of incidents involved attacks on people carrying out food-related activities, including farmers working in agricultural fields, humanitarian workers delivering food assistance, and marketgoers.
- 25% of incidents involved the looting of livestock or the killing and injuring of livestock.
- Persistent informal taxation and financial extortion by armed actors, including FARDC, Wazalendo, M23, Mayi Mayi militia, and ADF, contributed to putting a strain on food systems. This practice often involved the erection of checkpoints and farmers' access to agricultural land being restricted in Ituri and North Kivu provinces and was often accompanied by other forms of violence and intimidation.



Introduction

From January 2023 to May 2026, Insecurity Insight recorded 465 incidents of food-related violence across eastern DRC, underlining a continuation of persistent and repeated violence against local food systems in North Kivu and Ituri in particular. This includes 175 identified incidents in 2023, 108 in 2024 and 136 in 2025. The cumulative pattern of incidents observed over the period highlights the sustained disruption of local food systems and livelihoods in these areas, driving increased reliance on humanitarian food-aid which is underfunded and also affected by violence and insecurity.

These challenges are exacerbated by the ongoing and reverberating consequences of incidents of food-related violence. In many cases, one recorded incident represents an ongoing and pervasive issue that, while not recorded at every iteration, will continue to erode the food system over time. For example, in May 2026, armed members of the Allied Democratic Forces (ADF) reportedly looted livestock in Mambasa, Ituri province, and demanded a monthly payment of 30,000 Congolese Francs from farmers to access their agricultural fields.¹ This type of illegal taxation and extortion through violence and intimidation can affect multiple farmers in the area over an extended period of time.

In addition, the impact of food-related violence can take weeks, months or even years to fully manifest. In February 2025, for example, a farmer in Beni, North Kivu, was killed by a previously laid landmine², illustrating the often delayed impact that one act of violence can have on livelihoods and the safety of those working within the local food system. Similarly, the displacement of farmers from Beni in August 2025³ will ultimately reduce agricultural production as fields were left untended and harvests were disrupted, with consequences for food production and availability. When multiple farmers are displaced on an ongoing basis, incidents from the past continue to impact the food security of the present and future.

The result of these observations is that, even as incident numbers decrease, the full impact and reverberating effects of violent events can take weeks, months, or even years to be realised. This necessitates the implementation of the anticipatory mindset approach outlined below.

Adopting an Anticipatory Mindset

In conflict, monitoring patterns of damage and destruction can help to anticipate the predictable devastating needs in order to identify the mitigating measures that prevent the impact spreading and turning into devastating consequences. The anticipatory mindset is a specific form of anticipatory action to address the impacts of conflict, centred on the idea of proactivity informed by an analysis of available evidence and consideration of expected scenarios.⁴ It also advocates for a flexible and context-sensitive approach, such as flexible funding, rather than a response involving rigid structures. The key aim is to extensively analyse and continuously monitor and understand the threats to aid operations and food systems in order, as far as possible, to take proactive or early action to reduce the devastating impact that often follows conflict-violence, prevent its worst consequences and to sustain livelihoods and prevent food insecurity, avoidable deaths and displacement. While the most affected provinces, such as North Kivu and Ituri in this analysis, require urgent and immediate prioritisation to mitigate suffering and meet humanitarian needs, harm can be mitigated by applying the anticipatory mindset to all provinces across the DRC.

The anticipatory mindset includes:

- Understanding the level of destruction of the local food system and how it affects food needs in the short, medium and long-term.
- Understanding how narratives affect aid acceptance and adjusting access and security risk management strategies accordingly.
- Developing the capacity to link information on the impact of the conduct of hostilities to the needs assessments.
- Developing the capacity to assess acceptance in a polarised and changing context.
- Developing the capacity to support local partners, and volunteers, in their security risk management.
- Developing the capacity to act and implement action based on predicted changes at short notice.
- Developing the capacity to mitigate the immediate damage to local systems to strengthen resilience, including through adapted mental health support.
- Developing the capacity to advocate for the respect of International Humanitarian Law (IHL) in conflict to ensure the protection of food systems, health care and aid workers.

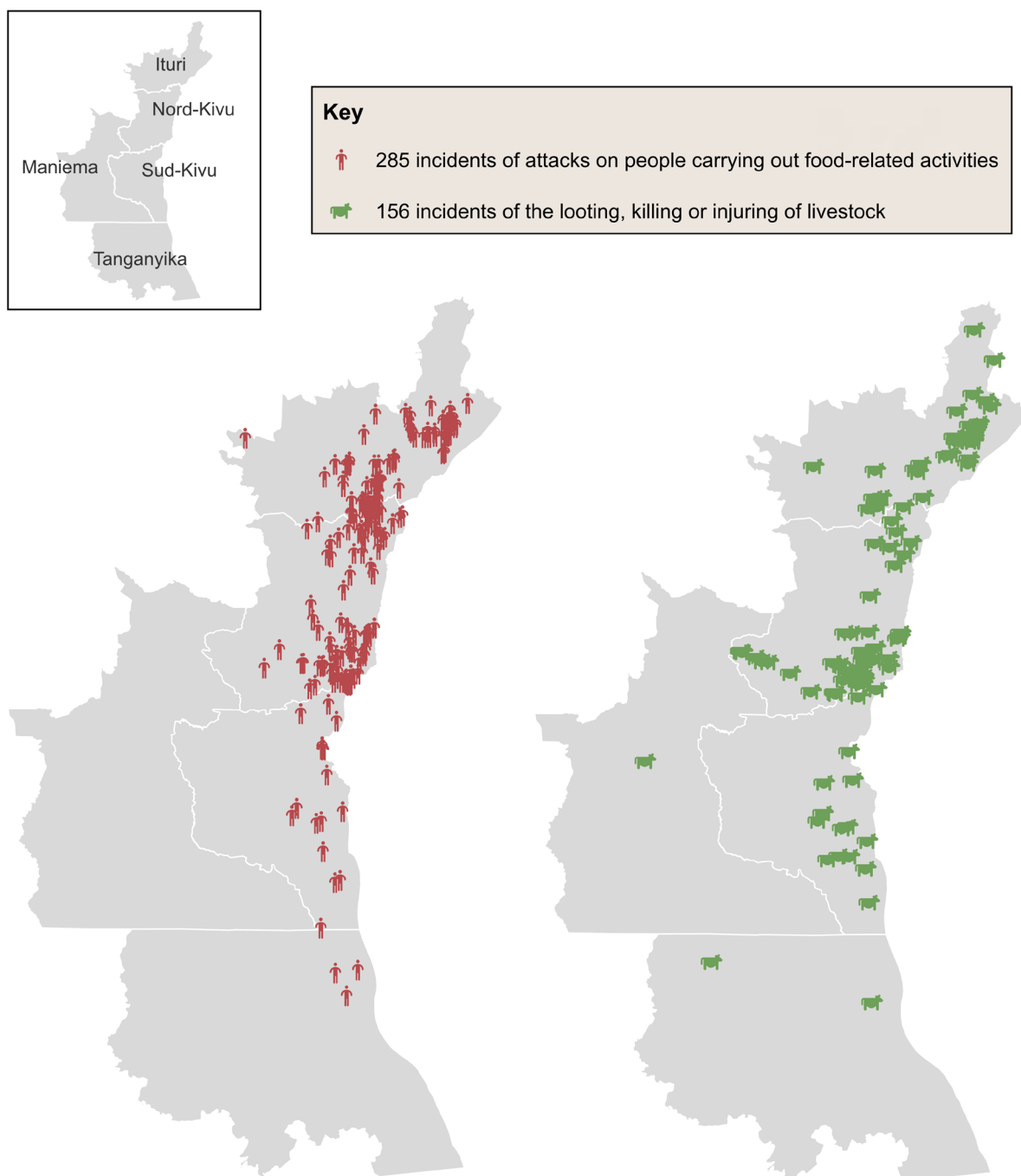
Patterns of violence, January 2023-May 2026

In support of the implementation of an anticipatory mindset approach to addressing food insecurity in eastern DRC, Insecurity Insight has identified and geo-located the most prominent forms of violence documented from January 2023-May 2026. These include 285 incidents of attacks on people carrying out food-related activities, over half of which were observed in North Kivu province (156 incidents) and 115 incidents of the looting, killing or injuring of livestock, also most prominently observed in North Kivu province (51 incidents).

Attacks against people engaged in food-related activities were the most frequently recorded form of violence recorded during the monitoring period, with at least 285 incidents documented. Although the number of incidents has declined steadily over time, from 117 in 2023, to 83 in 2024, to 67 in 2025, and 18 in the first half of 2026, this trend should not be interpreted as a proportional improvement in food security outcomes.

The legacy of repeated violence continues to undermine food systems long after individual incidents occur. Communities affected by attacks face enduring trauma, displacement, restricted access to agricultural land and markets, and significant material and financial losses. These cumulative impacts undermine the food system at all levels, from production, transportation, purchase, sale, consumption and humanitarian access. As a result, even as incident numbers fall, the consequences of past and ongoing violence continue to constrain recovery and threaten the resilience of affected communities. A comprehensive understanding of these events over time helps to build a more robust understanding of how food insecurity was created and how it may be addressed and prevented in the future.

Attacks against people engaged in food-related activities and the looting, killing and injuring of livestock were the most frequently recorded forms of violence in eastern DRC, January 2023-May 2026



Data source and visualisation: Insecurity Insight. Basemap data source: UN OCHA.

In addition to attacks on people carrying out food-related activities and the looting killing or injuring of livestock, analysis revealed incidents of the ongoing threat of persistent illegal taxation and financial extortion by armed actors, including FARDC, Wazalendo, M23, Mayi Mayi militia, and ADF, which often involved the erection of checkpoints and farmers' access to agricultural land being restricted in Ituri and North Kivu provinces and was often accompanied by other forms of violence and intimidation, indicating the systematic difficulties in food production and distribution.

End notes

1 FIVC DRC (linked to Anticipatory Action and Risk Mitigation of Food-Insecurity). Incident number 132506.

2 FIVC DRC (linked to Anticipatory Action and Risk Mitigation of Food-Insecurity). Incident number 93983

3 FIVC DRC (linked to Anticipatory Action and Risk Mitigation of Food-Insecurity). Incident number 117815

4 For further information, see: <https://bit.ly/AAMindsetOct2024>

Other resources

For detailed recommendations on conflict and hunger in the DRC, definitions of data categories and the methodology, see Insecurity Insight's in-depth report: Chronic Insecurity: How Armed Groups Undermine Food Security in Ituri and North Kivu Provinces (February 2025).

Anticipatory action (AA) involves “acting ahead of predicted hazardous events to prevent or reduce acute humanitarian impacts before they fully unfold.” Insecurity Insight's An Anticipatory Mindset explores how humanitarian organisations can move from reacting to crises to preparing for them before they unfold. Drawing on lessons from security risk management and community engagement, the report highlights how proactive analysis, conflict-sensitive planning, and smarter use of data can help aid agencies maintain access, protect staff, and deliver more effective support in conflict-affected settings. It makes the case for embedding anticipatory thinking across humanitarian programming to reduce harm, strengthen resilience, and improve outcomes for vulnerable communities.

How the Conduct of Conflict Affects Food Security and Health Care in Sudan examines how the methods and tactics used in Sudan's war are driving hunger, undermining health care, and deepening the humanitarian crisis. Drawing on evidence of attacks on hospitals, food systems, markets, aid operations, and civilian infrastructure, the report highlights the interconnected impacts of conflict on people's ability to access food and essential medical services. It offers recommendations to strengthen civilian protection and safeguard critical systems that communities depend on for survival during conflict.

More reports and guidance materials are available on our [website](#).

This document is published by Insecurity Insight, a Humanitarian to Humanitarian (H2H) organisation committed to the Humanitarian Principles. The analysis is based on Insecurity Insight's Food Insecurity and Violent Conflict (FIVC) dataset, an event-based dataset compiled by Insecurity Insight from open sources and partner contributions, and available for download on the [Humanitarian Data Exchange](#) (HDX).

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